

The O2 Cure Plug & Play Air Purifier

Is this your solution for clean and pure air indoors?

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Covid-19 made us realise the risks of improper hygiene and the contagiousness of airborne diseases. To that end, most of us have started taking preventive measures to protect ourselves. One such measure is using air purifiers. Now, there are plenty of air purifiers in the market from different brands and with different features and frills. Interestingly, the titular product we have with us has 'cure' in its name and claims to clean up to 99 per cent of SAR-COV-2 and other harmful elements in indoor air. It may be equipped to fight the Covid spread with novel PHI-Cell technology, but we have to take the brand's word for it. Why? Well, for one, the tech under the hood is patented and hence there is no alternative to compare it with. Secondly, there is no mechanism for us to replicate the lab-controlled tests conducted by the company and there is no built-in indicator to gauge its real-time performance. Still, we took it out for a spin and we believe this O2 Cure purifier justifies its Plug & Play moniker. Whether it justifies the hefty price tag depends on your wallet.

The first thing we noticed upon getting our hands on the O2 Cure air purifier is that it is compact and lightweight in design. You can easily lift it with one hand. The thing has a metallic chassis that seems hollow yet sturdy. Thanks to this build, you can mount it on a wall or just lay it horizontally on a table/desk. It won't take up too much space.

On the right side, there is an on/off switch which is the sole control option. It is flanked by a 2-pin socket. There are air outlets on both the right and left sides. On the bottom side, there is the inlet



grille. There is a mounting hole on the back of the device along with important Plug & Play specs. Overall, the device has a different aesthetic but because of its small form factor, you won't face any trouble in finding space for it in a home or office setting.

Under the hood you have the PHI Cell technology (patented by RGF Environmental Group, USA). It is said to release "friendly oxidizers" like Hydro-peroxide, Hydroxides, and Super Oxide Ions that remove harmful pollutants, VOCs, chemical gases, odour, and microbes from indoor air. The company claims this technology is "tested by Indian (CCMB-CSIR) and American (Innovative Bio-analysis) Virology Labs" for neutralising even the Coronavirus (SARS-COV-2) up to 99.67 per cent.

Beneath the PHI Cell, there is a suction fan that sucks polluted air in, which in

turn comes through an Electrostatic filter below the fan. This filter has to be cleaned every 30 days. Apart from that, there are no other filters like a HEPA or Carbon filter, but that's what differentiates it from the common kind of air purifiers in the market. Something else that's not present here is an Air Quality Indicator (AQI).

There's no point comparing it with the usual air purifiers (with HEPA or carbon filters) out there as while they tackle the particulate matter, this one is tasked with cleansing microbes, gases, odour, and viruses. Its role comes in preventing the viruses from cross-contamination. The company did share its test results with us upon signing an NDA. However, we couldn't replicate the tests conducted by the brand and we couldn't tell you how effective it is in what it claims. But, as for its air freshening capability, we did put it to the test and found it succeeds to some extent, but not always.

Before turning on the purifier, the Senseedge showed a reading of — 73 PM 2.5, 704 CO2, and 17 TVOC. After running the purifier for about 45 minutes, the results were 71 PM 2.5 level, 794 CO2, and 83 TVOC. At the office, before running the purifier, the Senseedge showed a reading of — 50 PM 2.5, 605 CO2, and 101 TVOC. Meanwhile, after running the purifier on for about an hour, the figures were 37 PM 2.5, 493 CO2, and 179 TVOC.

Coming to the odour, while cooking chicken or fish at home, the device was able to quell the smell considerably. We tested it with the smell of an incense stick and even kept it in an old musty storage room. Now, how well it works depends on the type and intensity of the odour. It doesn't fully get rid of all odour but it does a pretty decent job.

If you want a run-of-the-mill air purifier with HEPA or carbon filters, then this is not for you. It has a different value proposition. It is not for cleaning particulate matter. But, rather to purify the air from microbes, VOCs, and viruses. So, obviously, you can't measure its performance using typical metrics like CADR or AQI figures. Thus this is for those who are concerned about protection against airborne viral diseases, especially preventing cross-infection, and keeping foul smells at bay. 